

LECTURE 6: SELF IN THE SOCIAL WORLD 1 SELF-CONCEPT

Assoc. Prof. Kullaya Pisitsungkagarn
Ph.D. & DPsych.

OUTLINE FOR THE LECTURE

- Administrative Work
 - Exam outcomes to be announced within **2 weeks** after the exam.
- Self-concept
- Factors contributing to self-concept
- Self-concept & self-discrepancies
- Self-esteem & self-compassion

SELF-CONCEPT

SELF-CONCEPT

- Self-concept is an organized collection of **beliefs** that one has about oneself (self-schemas)
 - Self-concept is partially based on **our perception**.



SELF-CONCEPT

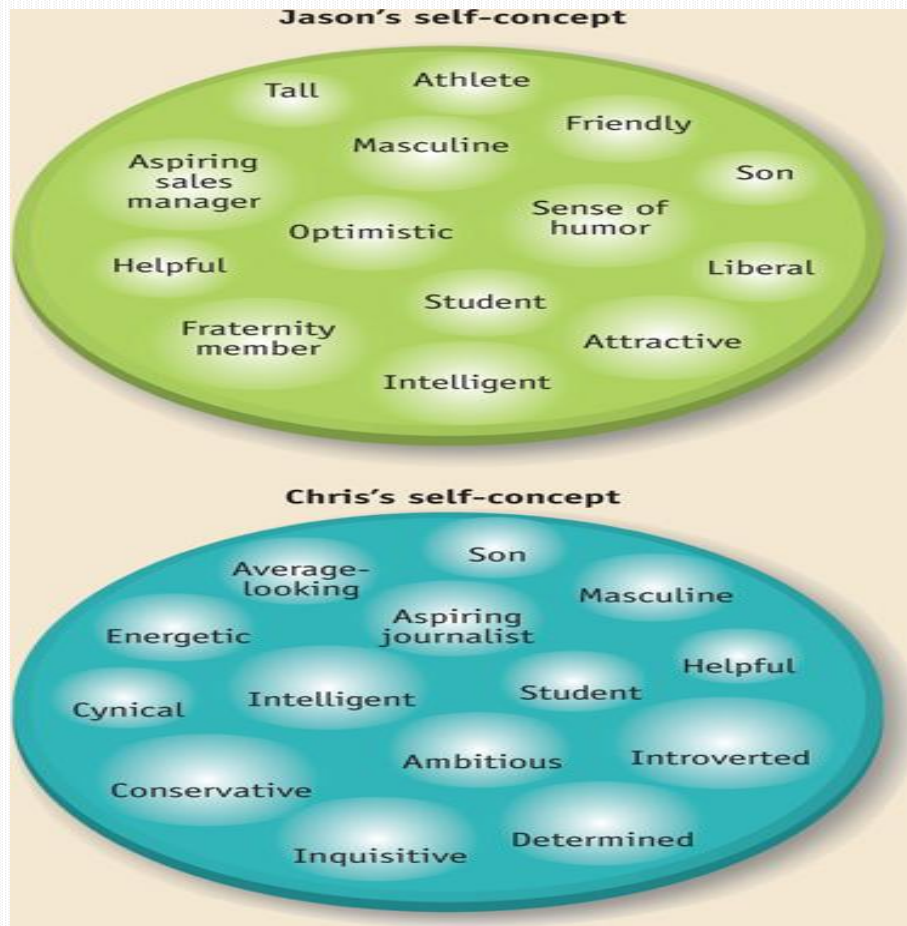
- Who are you as a person?

- Jot down as many answer as you can in 1 minute.

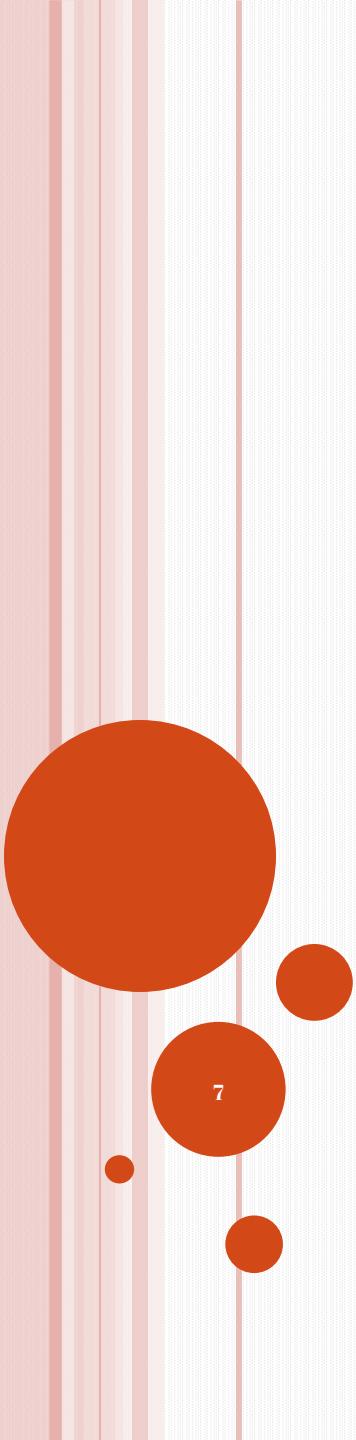
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SELF-CONCEPT



- Self-concept can be related to **personality traits, abilities, physical features, values, goals, social roles, possible/ideal selves, etc.**



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT

7



1) SELF-PERCEPTION

8

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- Our self-concept is **partially** based on our **explanatory styles**, or the way we explain the **causes** of what happens in our life.
 - With different explanations, we come up with **different conclusions** about ourselves, our self-concepts.



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION



- How would Jane perceive herself as a partner (i.e., positive or negative self-concept) with the 2 explanations after **breaking up with her boyfriend**?
 - A) We're incompatible--- just two people with two totally different lifestyles. I might come across someone who fits with me later.
 - B) I'm not good enough for him. I don't deserve him... I failed.

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- Would Jane gain the same level of confidence as a partner (i.e., positive or negative self-concept) with the 2 self-talks on **her wedding day**?
 - A) “It feels like a dream. I can’t believe I’ve made it. I can’t see what he sees in me. It’s just a pure luck.”
 - B) “Finally, I find someone who truly appreciates me!”



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

Optimistic and **pessimistic** explanatory styles differ in two dimensions:

		Stability dimension	
		Unstable cause (temporary)	Stable cause (permanent)
Internal-external dimension	Internal cause	Effort Mood Fatigue	Ability Intelligence
	External cause	Luck Chance Opportunity	Task difficulty

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- Positive self-concept is maintained when we use **optimistic explanatory styles**:
 - Keep in mind that negative events might **not last forever** (i.e., unstable), and sometimes are **external** to our control.
 - Positive events are viewed as **internal** to our control--- Give yourself some credits for them.

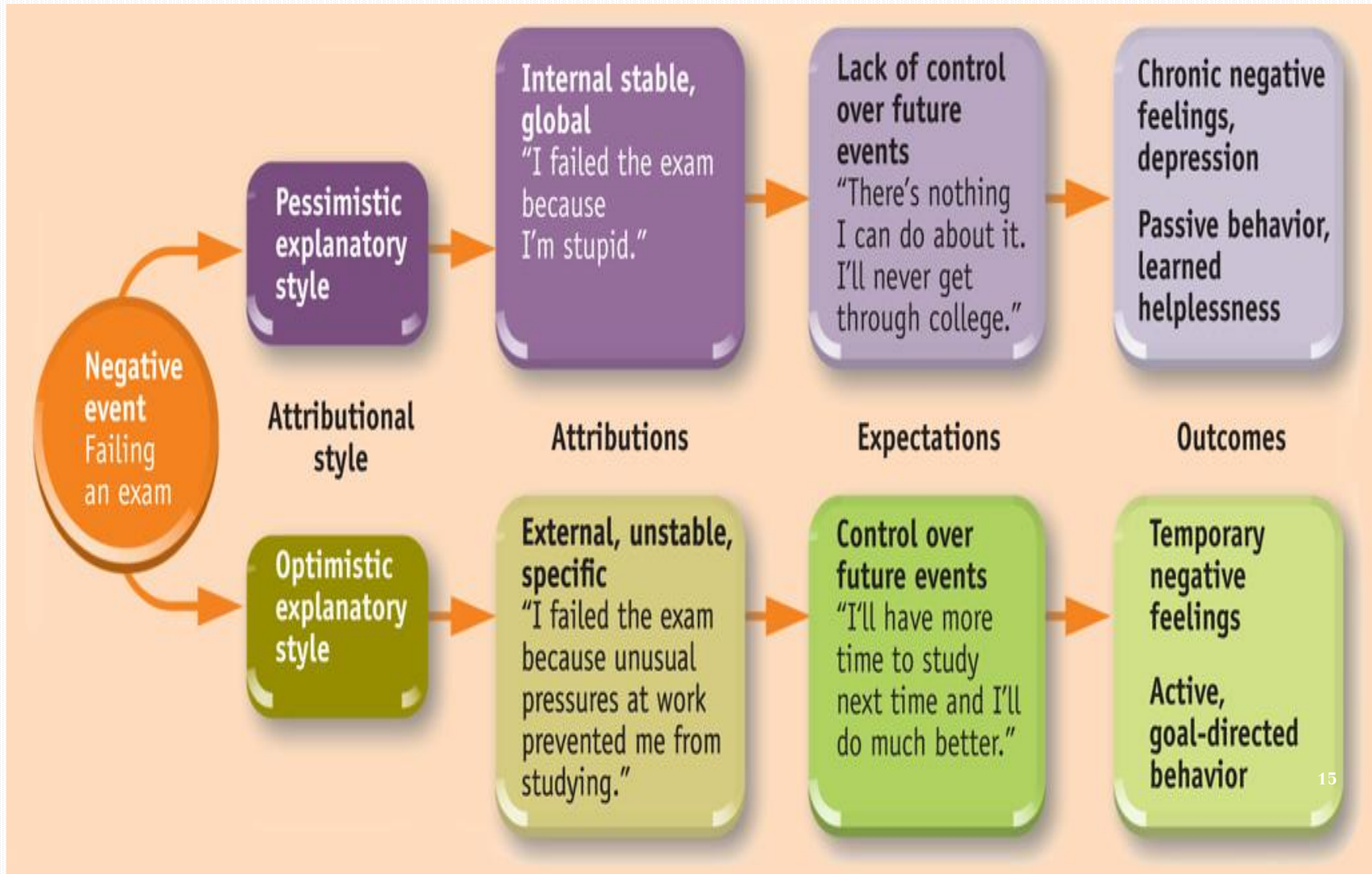


FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION



- Negative self-concept become worse when you use pessimistic explanatory styles:
 - Negative events are viewed as **stable and internal** to you.
 - Positive events are viewed as **external** to you--- you don't take the credit for them.

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- Whereas there are times when we have to take the blames for negative circumstances, keep in mind that:
 - **Nothing** lasts forever.
 - We remain entitled to taking the **credits** for the good things we did.
 - If the explanation is unclear, **why not** consider the optimistic explanatory style.



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- An optimistic explanatory style involves attributing setbacks to **external, unstable, and specific factors**.
- An extremely **optimistic** explanation when you **had a fender bender**:



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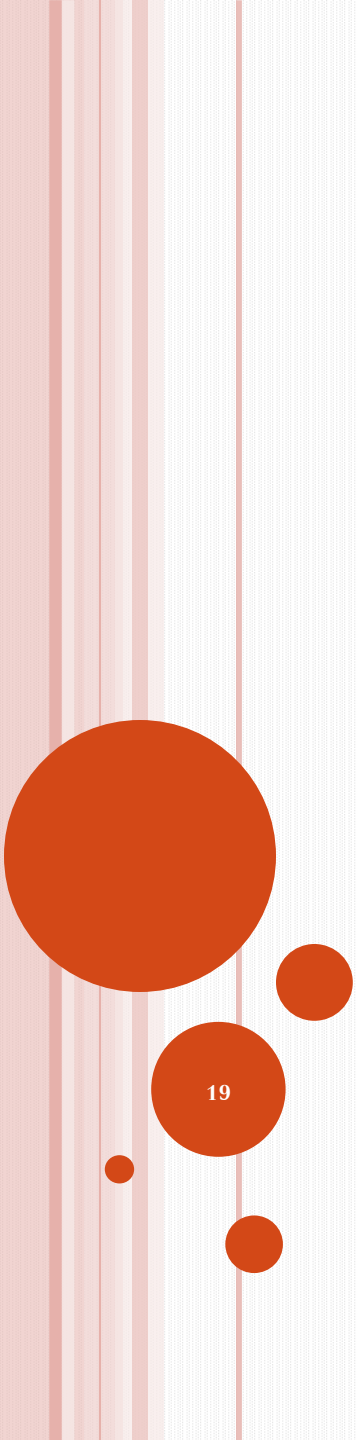
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FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 1) SELF-PERCEPTION

- A pessimistic explanatory style involves attributing setbacks to **internal, stable, and global factors**.
- An extremely **pessimistic** explanation when **had a fender bender** :
 -
 -





2) SOCIAL COMPARISON

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 2) SOCIAL COMPARISON

- o **Comparing ourselves with others** leads to our self-concept (Social Comparison Theory; Festinger, 1954).



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 2) SOCIAL COMPARISON

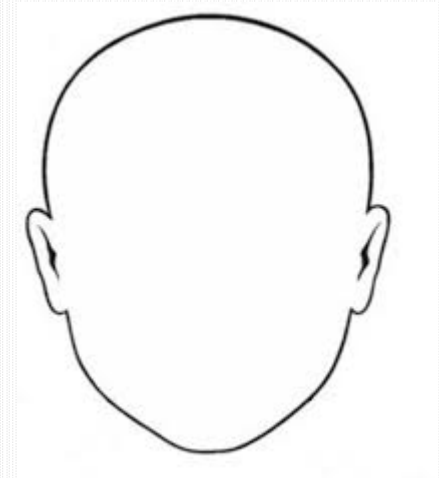
- A set of people whom we compare ourselves to can lead to different self-concepts.
 - **Upward comparison:** Using **superior** reference groups so as to improve **ourselves**
 - **Downward comparison:** Using **inferior** reference groups so as to improve **our self-concept**



3) SOCIAL FEEDBACK

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 3) SOCIAL FEEDBACK

- Our self-perceptions can be distorted.
 - Feedback from others is important in **balancing** with our own observations.
 - We may view ourselves more or less critically, depending on the feedback from those around us.
 - Good feedback providers give you a **realistic** feedback but they are **optimistic** in their explanatory styles.
 - Identify a good feedback provider of yours:



4) CULTURAL VALUES

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 4) CULTURAL VALUES

- Cultural values & self-concept

- People from **individualistic** cultures tend to have an **independent** view of the self.
 - Viewing themselves as unique, self-contained, and distinct from others.
- People from **collectivistic** cultures tend to have an **interdependent** view of the self.
 - Viewing themselves as more connected to others.

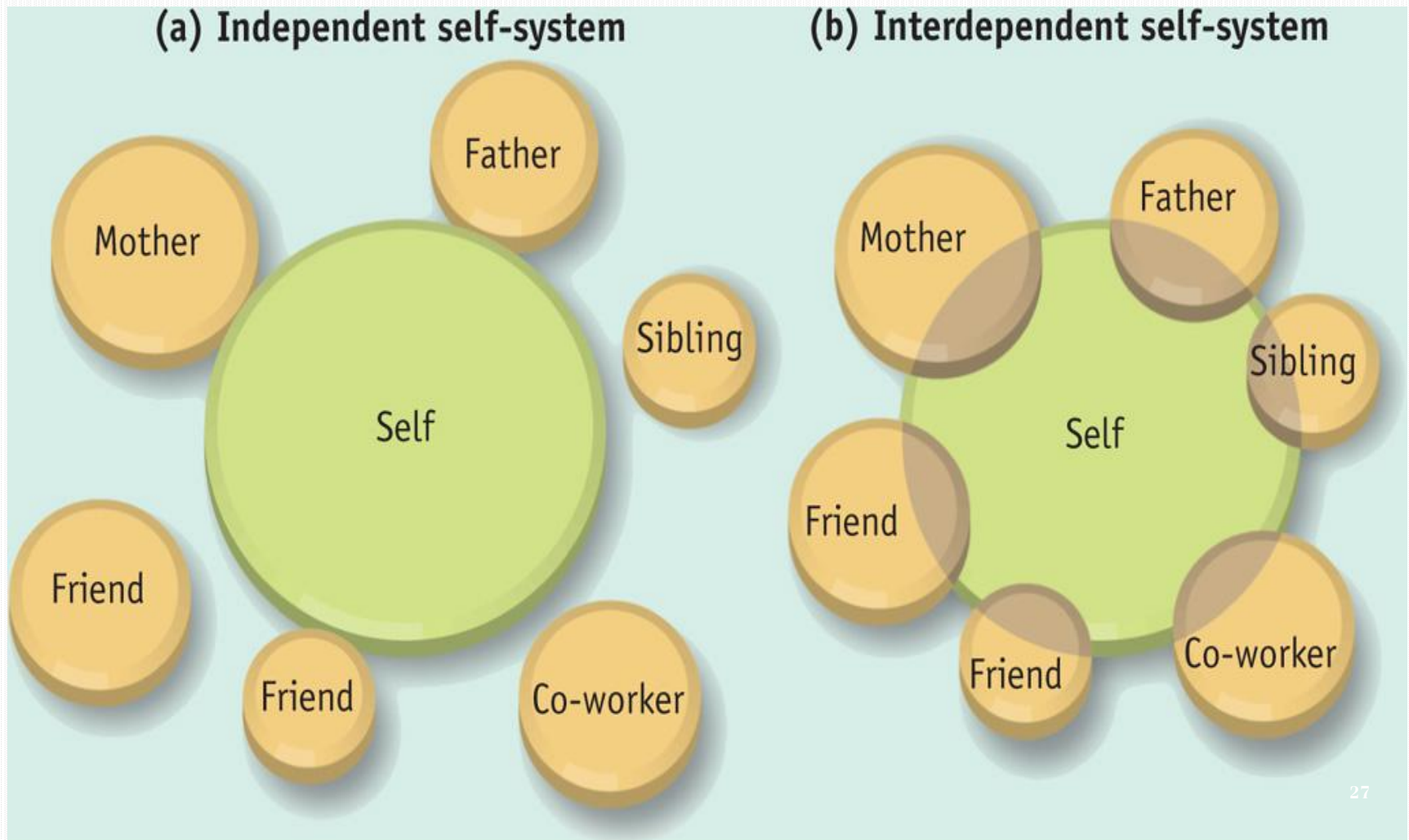


FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 4) CULTURAL VALUES

- Cultural values & self-concept
 - In individualistic cultures, self-concept is defined more in terms of **personal attributes or characteristics**.
 - In collectivistic cultures, self-concept is defined more in terms of the **groups one belongs to**.



FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO SELF-CONCEPT: 4) CULTURAL VALUES



SELF-CONCEPT & SELF-DISCREPANCIES

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SELF-CONCEPT & SELF-DISCREPANCIES



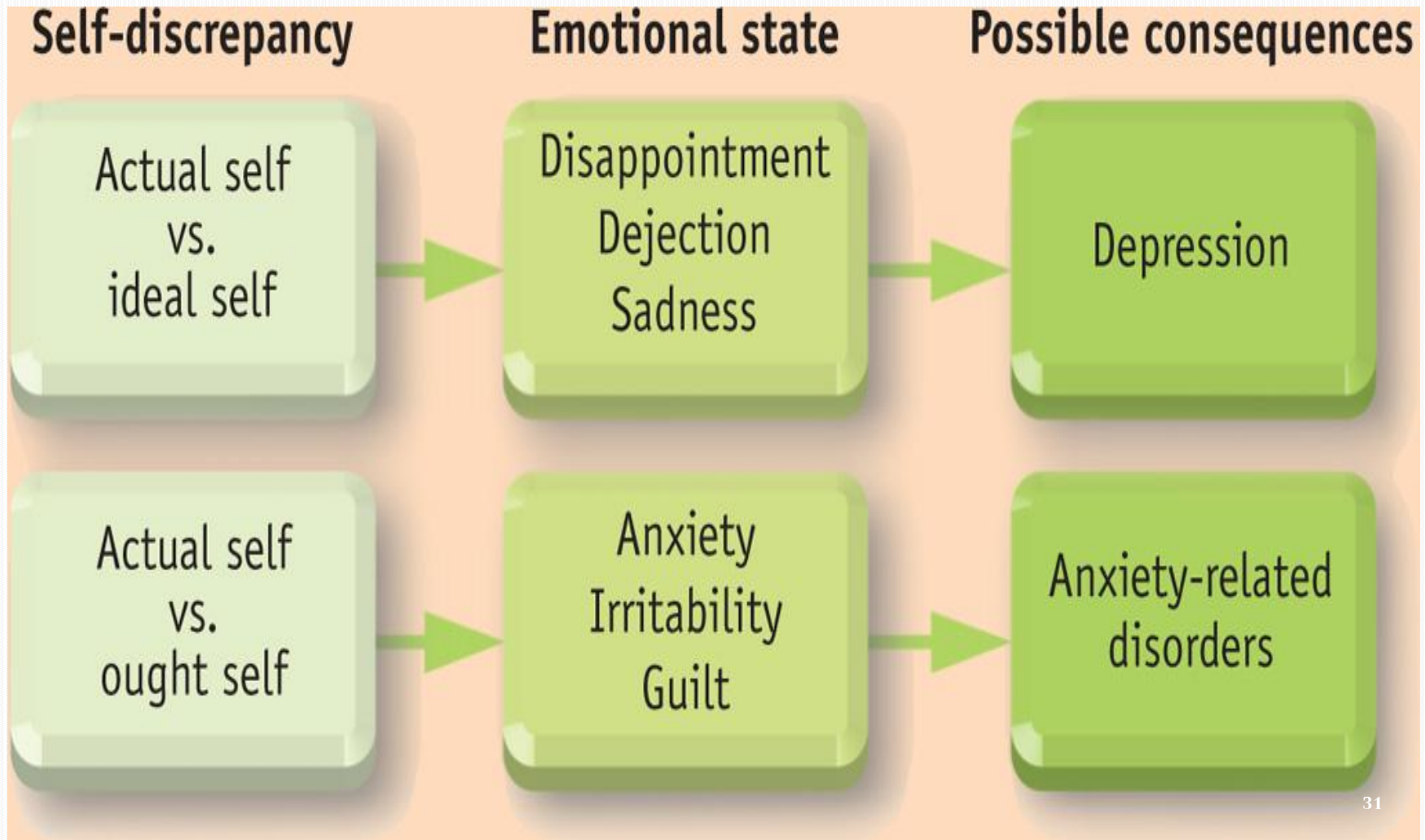
- Self-concept can lead to various self-perceptions:
 - An actual self: Qualities you **actually** possess.
 - An ideal self: Qualities you **would like** to have.
 - An ought self: Qualities people think they **should** possess.

SELF-CONCEPT & SELF-DISCREPANCIES

- Self-discrepancies: **Mismatches** between the actual, ideal, and/or ought selves can lead to different feelings.

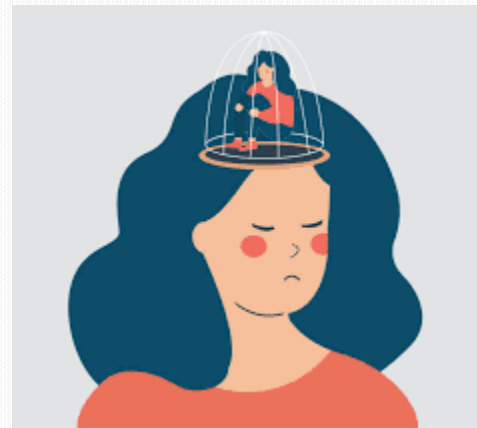
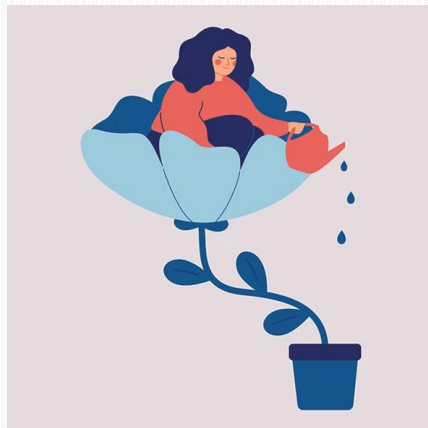


SELF-CONCEPT & SELF-DISCREPANCIES



COPING WITH SELF-DISCREPANCIES

- People cope with self-discrepancies by
 - Adaptively **changing** their behaviors to be more in line with the ideal or ought self.
 - Maladaptively blunting self-awareness by
 - **Avoiding** situations that increase self-awareness
 - By using **distractions** (e.g., food, alcohol).



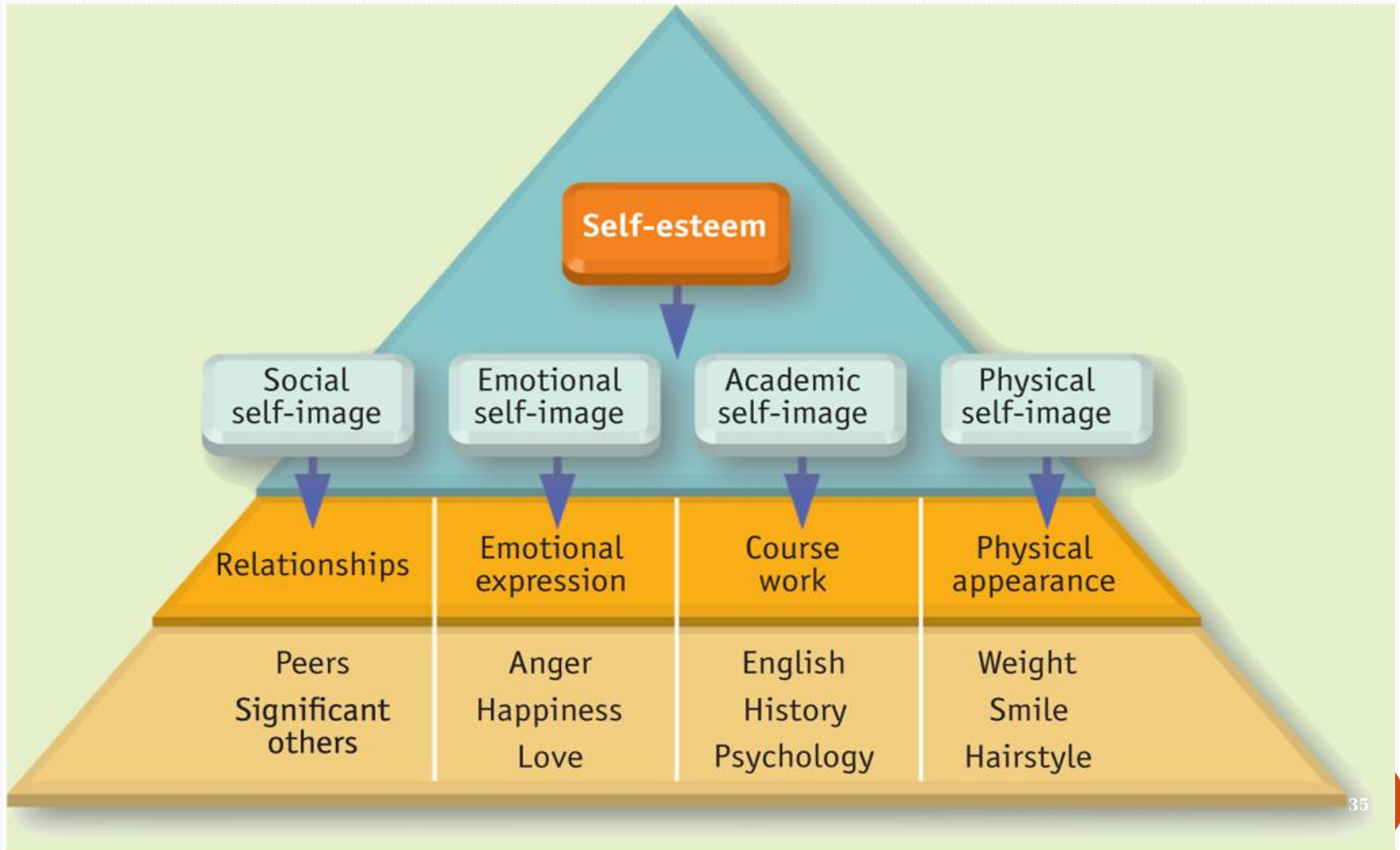
SELF-ESTEEM

SELF-ESTEEM

- Self-esteem refers to “one’s overall assessment of one’s **worth as a person**”.
- It is a **global** evaluation of various aspects of one’s self-concepts.
- The evaluation, however, is affected by how well one excels in **the self-concept one sees as important**.

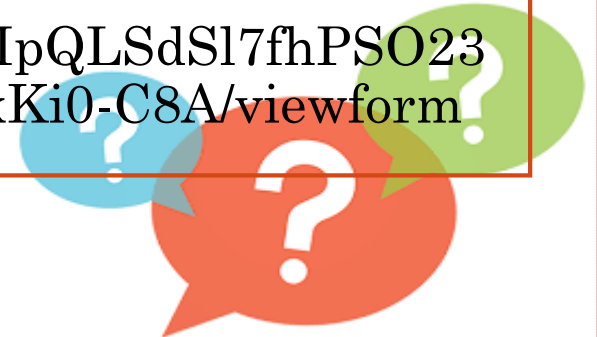


SELF-ESTEEM



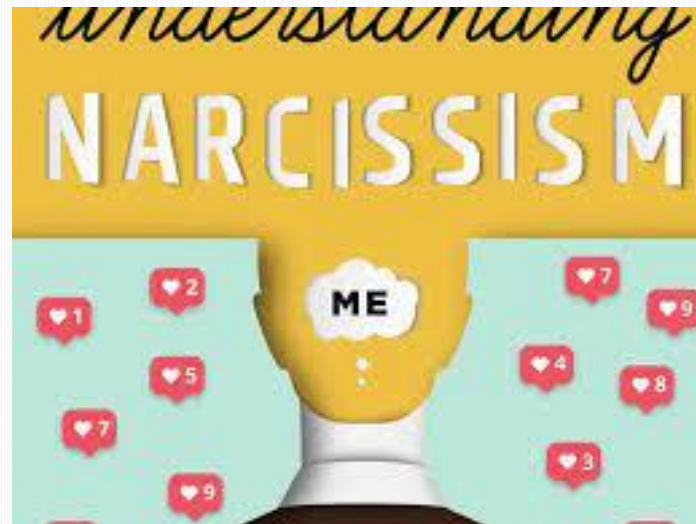
SELF-ESTEEM

- Self-esteem has been shown to be associated with
 - Happiness
 - The sense of being more likeable and attractive
 - Persistence in the face of failure and better coping with setbacks.
 - Achievement
- Check out your self-esteem:
 - https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdSl7fhPSO23B_585SaJzi8ub3MdclTQb_sYPDT5TxKi0-C8A/viewform



SELF-ESTEEM VS. NARCISSISM

- High self-esteem vs. narcissism
 - Narcissism, or a tendency to regard oneself as **grandiosely important**, is **pathological** and different from high self-esteem, a healthier trait.



SELF-ESTEEM VS. NARCISSISM

- High self-esteem vs. narcissism: Narcissistic individuals
 - Are preoccupied with **fantasies of success**.
 - Believe they deserve **special treatment**.
 - React **aggressively** when their view of themselves (ego) is threatened.



SELF-ESTEEM VS. SELF-COMPASSION

- Self-esteem is **not free** from criticisms
 - With **unhealthy self-esteem** (i.e., self-esteem that is gained from stepping over/looking down on others), negativity could ensue.
 - Self-compassion, or a **mindful** acceptance of one's flaws/limitations **without being judgmental** toward oneself but recognizing that the flaws are **common humanity**, is sometimes proposed to be adopted instead of self-esteem.



SELF-COMPASSION

- Self-compassion, or the compassionate way in which you handle your **flaws and limitations** (Neff, 2003), can be used to enhance your mental health & well-being.
- Self-compassion has been shown to be associated with a host of **positive outcomes** in intrapersonal & interpersonal relationships.
- <https://self-compassion.org/>



Mindfulness

Being aware of the physical, emotional, or mental pain of the moment.



Self-kindness

Treating ourselves with kindness, considering our own needs.



Common Humanity

Recognizing that these experiences are a normal part of being human.

SOME BASIC SELF-HELP STRATEGIES

- Various components of self-compassion
 - **Mindfulness**: How you mindfully and calmly view & manage own inadequacies.
 - **Self-kindness**: How gently and kindly you take care of yourself when you come across own inadequacies.
 - **Connectedness/Common Humanity**: How well you recognize that imperfections are common human experiences.



Mindfulness

Being aware of the physical, emotional, or mental pain of the moment.



Self-kindness

Treating ourselves with kindness, considering our own needs.



Common Humanity

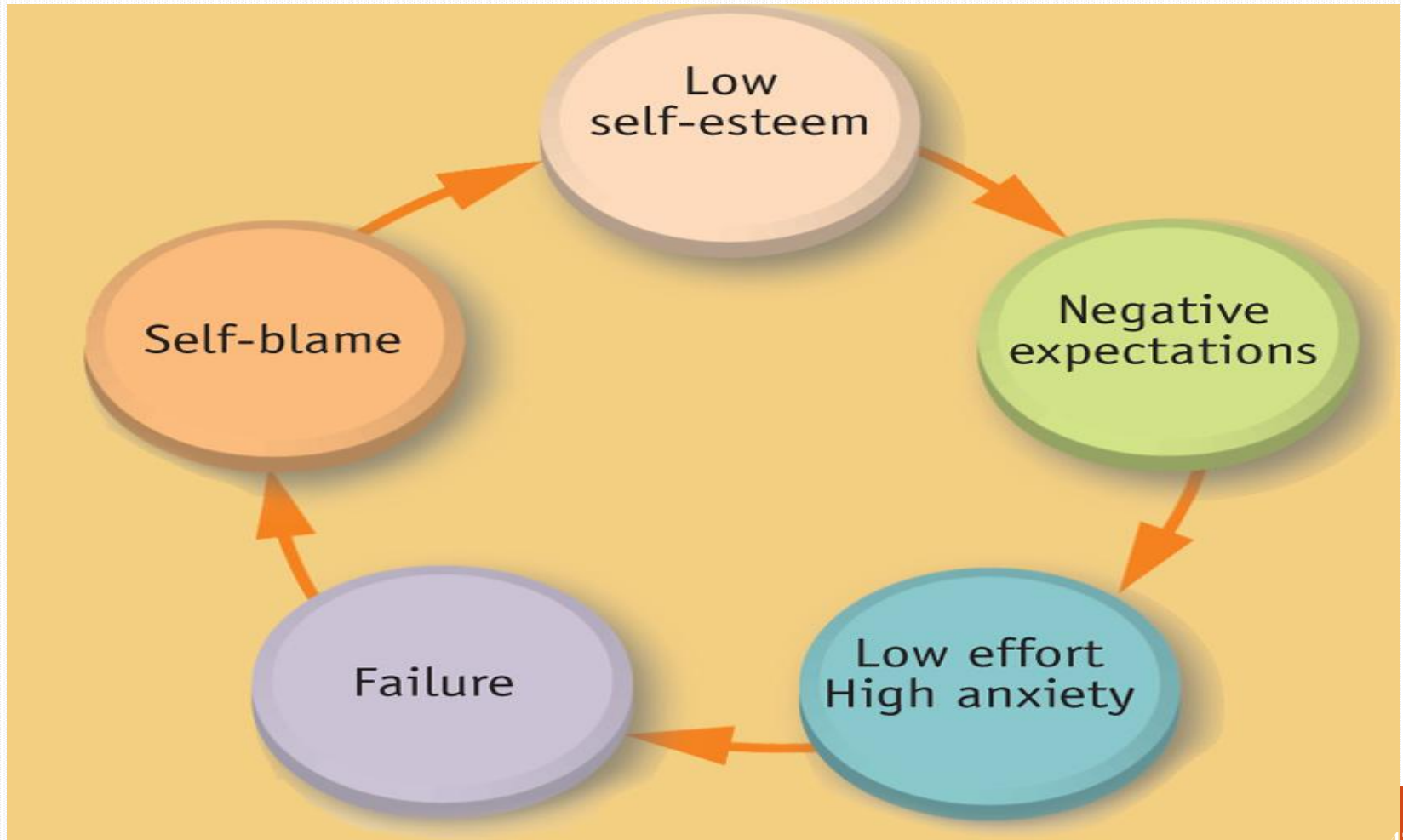
Recognizing that these experiences are a normal part of being human.

SELF-ESTEEM



- Still, building **a healthy self-esteem** is important.
- Those with low self-esteem are
 - More discouraged by **failure**.
 - More **anxiety** in relationships.
 - More prone to **depression**.

SELF-ESTEEM



TIPS FOR SELF-ESTEEM ENHANCEMENT

- Learn more about yourself.
 - What are **important** for you?
 - What are you **good at**?
- Set your own **realistic goals** that emphasize your strengths.



TIPS FOR SELF-ESTEEM ENHANCEMENT



- Modify **negative self-talk** & use a more **optimistic explanatory style** when confronting successes and failures.
- Surround yourself with **those with positive outlooks**.